7.2 Alpine Landscape at Pitschenbergalm, Austria

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Location and surroundings

The Pitschenbergalm is an alp (high alpine meadow used for seasonal grazing by cattle and sheep) located in the Pfarrwerfen municipality, c.33 km south of the city of Salzburg in the rugged and heavily karstified Tennengebirge range, a part of the Northern Limestone Alps. The only area with enough vegetation for grazing is a valley-like gap running c.4 km north to south at an altitude of 1730-1930 m above sea level. This area is made up of the "outer" Vordere Pitschenbergalm and the "inner" Hintere Pitschenbergalm (Figs.17 & 18), divided by a rocky outcrop (the Windischriedel) at c.1925m above sea level, which holds the only recent man-made building, a hiking hut called the Leopold Happisch Haus. All other agricultural building and fencing structures from prehistory to the 20th century have been abandoned and are (for the most part) still visible as ruins or stone alignments.

Reasons for assessment

From 2012 to 2015, research and archaeological investigations by the Federal Monuments Authority and ANISA, the Association for Alpine Research, led to the identification of a whole series of deserted alpine pastures, which were then surveyed and photo-documented. Smalls finds and dating of samples (taken mostly from sondages of 20 × 20 cm) allow a chronological assignment of the ruined structures, ranging from the Early Bronze Age (mid-20th to early 18th century BC) to the Modern Age (18th to 19th century AD). The finds of flint artefacts on the headland of the small pond on the Vordere Pitschenbergalm make it clear that the area was already known to people in the Neolithic period (5th-3rd millennium BC). However, no trend could be attached to these scattered single finds so far. Based on these research results, the Federal Monuments Authority in 2020 placed the Pitschenbergalm on the (purely tentative) list of the highest-ranking archaeological monuments in Austria, as part of an in-house evaluation project. The site was therefore added to the 2021 official annual list of monuments to be assessed for the status of protection by law. Due to unfavourable weather (early snow) in this high altitude, the assessment in the field was carried out in the following summer, which resulted in an expert report on the site's significance. The protection status was proclaimed by notice from the Federal Monuments Authority on 15 November 2022.

Description of site

The relatively remote location of the mountain pasture has favoured the particularly good preservation of the archaeological monuments. A total of 19 prehistoric and historic building structures have been documented. These remains of alpine huts, stables as well as pens, enclosures and a lime kiln have only been known to science for a relatively short time. They are found mostly in places with favourable sunlight and little danger from avalanches, as well as offering dry ground on slightly elevated positions. The structures reveal themselves as dry-set stone layers of limestone, with (in the case of formerly roofed buildings) an approximately rectangular ground plan and openings for the entrance.

Figure 17: Vordere Pitschenbergalm (view to the north). (Andreas Picker).

Figure 18: Hintere Pitschenbergalm (view to the east). (Andreas Picker).

Figure 19: Hintere Pitschenbergalm: Bronze Age U-shaped hut site. (Andreas Picker).

Figure 20: Hintere Pitschenbergalm: Ruin of the early modern alp hut. (Andreas Picker).

On the Hintere Pitschenbergalm, there is evidence of human activity beginning as early as the Early Bronze Age and continuing into the Late Bronze Age (Urnfield Period). Two hut sites can be identified by heavily abraded, U-shaped ground plans of approximately 5 × 5 m dated to the 14th to 12th century BC (Fig.19). A larger, multi-roomed structure yielded dates from the 20th to 12th century BC, but there is also a late medieval date of the late 13th to early 15th century AD. The prehistoric ruins might have been re-used or made habitable later. Human activities of the Late Iron Age can be attested at the Vordere Pitschenbergalm for the 2nd to 1st century BC. In two cases, rocks or lintel blocks were used as shelter from wind and weather. A rectangular hut ground plan on the Hintere Pitschenbergalm proves that the high alpine site was also in use during the Roman imperial period (late 1st and first half of the 2nd century AD). Both alpine pastures were also used in the early Middle Ages: a two-roomed building with an attached animal pen (at the foot of the Windischriedel) as well as a small structure on the Hintere Pitschenbergalm date to the 7th and 8th centuries AD respectively. The first written document regarding the Pitschenbergalm dates from 1749. This source presumably refers to the building in the northwest of the Hintere Pitschenbergalm, the foundation walls of which are still well preserved above ground (Fig.20). A wood sample from within dates to the early 18th century. The Hintere Pitschenbergalm was already partly abandoned in the second half of the 19th century. The impressive, now ruinous remains of the two-storey house in the north of the Vordere Pitschenbergalm, however, bear witness to the alpine dairy production and hunting grounds of the 19th and early 20th centuries. By 1978, the agricultural installations were no longer in operation.

Assessing significance – methods

Based on Austrian monument protection law, the assessment of the monument's "historical, artistic or general cultural significance" is based on "quality, as well as sufficient quantity, diversity and dispersion" and "to what extent a historical documentation can be achieved through the preservation of the monument".

Historical significance

The remains of alpine huts, stables and pens on the Pitschenbergalm date back to those periods in which humans increased seasonal high alpine pasture use and alpine farming in the Eastern Alps: from the Bronze Age, the late Iron Age and Roman periods, the Early Middle Ages and from the Late Middle Ages to the more recent Modern Age. Its outstanding historical significance is due to its long or repeated use through the ages. In a relatively small area, almost four millennia of human activity can be traced. Therefore, the Bronze Age to modern remains of alpine huts, stables and pens on the Pitschenbergalm are of national (or supra-regional) historical significance.

Diversity/Dispersion: Even though remains of deserted buildings and structures on high alpine pastures are quite common in Austria, the Pitschenbergalm stands out among other places. This assemblage of individual objects shows great cohesiveness within a definable space. Also, there are few comparable sites that have been researched and explored so well. For example, nearly all the structures on the Pitschenbergalm have been radiocarbon dated, which results in a concise picture of settlement development. In contrast to other archaeologically dated deserted alps (such as on

the Dachstein plateau or other sites in western Austria), all the periods are well attested in a relatively small area on the Pitschenbergalm.

Historical documentation (scientific potential/ perspective): The "historical significance" of the Pitschenbergalm's remains is not just a general attribution based on intrinsic factors like age and state of preservation. They are valued material sources pertaining to the historical development of seasonal alpine pasture use and therefore form an "archive" in the ground for future scientific research. The remains possess a particularly high degree of intactness and authentic preservation.

General cultural significance (social impact/ perception)

The Pitschenbergalm may be regarded as an entire cultural landscape characterised by archaeological monuments, most of which are (partly) visible above ground due to the slow formation of soil. The remoteness of this high alpine pasture, which is still used today for sheep grazing, has led to a good preservation of the archaeological remains. Their situation within a relatively closed micro-landscape between high mountaintops is in itself a defining aspect of the monument, even though purely "natural" elements are not included in monument protection. Despite their remoteness, the archaeological remains are just visible and accessible enough to hikers and small groups of visitors. Therefore, they show great potential as relatable landmarks and identity-forming places to society today.